

ROTTEN FATE
Bilal Ahmed Qureshi with disfigured fruit in Kolipora, Budgam

irrigation in the region, is also seeing a 70-year low. According to a study, titled 'Mapping of climate change hotspots in Indian forests', by the Forest Survey of India (FSI) and the Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS), Pilani, the heat is projected to increase further by 2030 in J&K, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand. These Himalayan states, the study predicts, will experience the 'highest increase' in temperature in 2030, 2050 and 2085, and the least increase, and sometimes even decline, in rainfall.

Climate change was a primary impetus for the conversion of agricultural land to horticultural use since the latter requires comparatively less irrigation. A 2020 study, titled 'Linking the recent glacier retreat and depleting and streamflow patterns with land system changes in Kashmir Himalaya, India', carried out by the Geoinformatics department of Kashmir University along with the department of environmental science, Nichols College, Dudley, USA, corroborated that the land system changes had a cumulative impact on the depleting streamflow and economic dividends from apple orchards. Statistics reflect that the area under irrigation-intensive agriculture has shrunk by 39 per cent whereas orchards have expanded by 177 per cent between 1980 and 2017.

GROWERS' UNIONS PROJECT A 40 PER CENT DROP IN APPLE YIELD FROM LAST YEAR

However, the changing weather patterns are now taking a toll on the horticulture sector too, according to Prof. Ashiq Hussain, an agronomist at the Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences & Technology (SKUAST) in Kashmir. Apples, for instance, need 1,400 hours of 0-7°C temperatures in winters to sprout buds or flowers. "But the rise in winter temperatures results in fall of flowers or bud bursts in spring," he says. "Similarly, when there is increase in temperature and humid-